

module-13-indic-ecology - Darshana (60-min workshop)

IKS Curriculum - senior band

Module 13 — Indic Ecology — Vasudhaiva Kuṭumbakam (Darśana)

Sanskrit: *Vasudhaiva Kuṭumbakam* · **Band:** Senior (9-12) · **Duration:** 60 min · **Path:** Darśana (Workshop)

“The world is one family” — Indian ecological frameworks.

Darśana note. This workshop condenses Module 13’s full 10-day arc into one hour. For the deeper version — daily lesson plans, quizzes, assessments, slide decks — switch to [Adhyayana](#) (the Full Course path).

Opening hook · 5 min

Project: (a) Mahā Upaniṣad 6.71-73, (b) IPCC AR6 climate-emergency declaration. “2500 years separate them, yet they ask the same questions: how do humans relate to the non-human? Today’s workshop reads classical Indian ecology against modern climate ethics.”

Core idea · 15 min

Indic ecology — frameworks and the climate present.

1. **Vasudhaiva Kuṭumbakam** (Mahā Upaniṣad 6.71-73). Origin verse for “Earth as family” framing. Used today in Indian foreign policy, environmental rhetoric.
2. **Atharva Veda Pṛthivī Sūkta (12.1)**: 63-verse hymn to Earth as goddess and substrate. Read alongside Lovelock’s Gaia hypothesis (1979).
3. **Iṣopaniṣad 1**: *īśāvāsyam idaṁ sarvaṁ* — “all this is to be inhabited by the divine.” Foundational sustainability ethic.
4. **Bhagavad Gītā 3.10-14**: yajña cycle. Modern parallel: ecological reciprocity in indigenous-knowledge frameworks (Robin Wall Kimmerer, *Braiding Sweetgrass*).
5. **Sacred groves**: ~13,000 in India (Gadgil & Vartak 1981). Biodiversity = species/area significantly higher than non-protected.

Honest framing: ancient practice was imperfect. Soil erosion, hunting pressures, caste-restricted access existed. Use the FRAMEWORKS to inspire modern practice; don't mythologise pre-modern practice.

Demonstration · 10 min

Source-critical reading. Project (a) Mahā Upaniṣad 6.71-73, (b) IPCC AR6 SPM excerpt. Pairs identify: where do the ethical claims overlap? Where do they diverge? Where does one fill a gap the other has?

Source moment · 5 min

Direct verse. Mahā Upaniṣad 6.71-73:

*ayaṁ nijaḥ paro veti gaṇanā laghu-cetasām / udāra-caritānām tu vasudhaiva
kuṭumbakam //*

“The reckoning of ‘this is mine, that is another’s’ belongs to the narrow-minded. To the noble-hearted, the Earth itself is one family.”

Note: NOT “all humans” — *vasudhā* (Earth) includes all life, all elements. The moral scope is the entire biosphere.

Hands-on activity · 15 min

Climate-ethics essay. Each student writes 400 words: “*Indic ecology and modern climate ethics both ask: how should humans treat the non-human? Compare ONE specific principle from each tradition. Where do they agree? Diverge?*”

Reflection + take-home · 10 min

“*India is the world’s 3rd-largest CO2 emitter (2024). Its tradition includes vasudhaiva kuṭumbakam. Discuss the gap. What’s needed to close it?*”

Go deeper into Adhyayana

The 10 days you’re skipping if you only do this workshop:

- **Day 01** — Vasudhaiva kuṭumbakam — the founding verse
- **Day 02** — Five elements as ecological frame
- **Day 03** — Rivers as sacred

- **Day 04** — Sacred groves
- **Day 05** — Yajña cycle — Gītā 3.10-14
- **Day 06** — Pṛthivī Sūkta — Atharva Veda 12.1
- **Day 07** — Iṣopaniṣad mantra 1
- **Day 08** — Climate change context
- **Day 09** — From ancient to action
- **Day 10** — Project pitch + assessment

→ [Open the Adhyayana track for this module](#) to access all 10 days, the 4-audience PDFs, the slide deck, the quizzes, and the project rubric.